

Last great galley battle
The victory of the Holy League over the Ottoman navy at Lepanto in 1571 is generally believed to mark the end of the age of galleys. Nevertheless, galleys continued to play an important part in sea battles in the Mediterranean and the Baltic throughout the 17th and 18th centuries.

Indian Ocean as far as east Africa. The decision of the Ming to withdraw from such maritime adventures after the 1430s was one of the turning points of world history.

NEW OCEAN-GOING POWERS

As Ming China turned inward, the states along Europe's Atlantic seaboard sought to exploit their maritime skills to capture the wealth of the luxury trade that previously had always passed through the Mediterranean from Asia to Europe. At the end of the 15th century the Portuguese found their way around southern Africa into the Indian Ocean, while Christopher Columbus, sailing in the name of the Spanish crown, accidentally landed in the West Indies. The result was a total shift in the European—and global—balance of power. The future lay with the ocean-going sailing ships of northern and western Europe, armed with cannon to make them impressive fighting machines engaging in a new kind of naval warfare.

GALLEY SWANSONG

As this fundamental change took place, however, an intense power struggle developed in the Mediterranean that brought the age of galley warfare to an epic climax. The rapid rise of the Muslim Ottoman Empire, which conquered the Byzantine capital Constantinople in 1453, confronted the Christian states of the Mediterranean with a formidable new enemy. The Ottomans possessed impressive resources, great organizational skills, and an apparently unstoppable will to power. While the Ottoman sultans created a large galley fleet to support military operations against Christian-ruled Mediterranean islands, their vassals and allies, the Barbary corsairs of North Africa raided and pillaged the coasts of Italy and preyed upon merchant shipping. The vast battle of Lepanto, fought in 1571 between an alliance of Christian states and the Ottomans and the Barbary corsairs, was the last great engagement of the long age of galley warfare in Europe.

Although the ramming, grappling, and boarding at Lepanto would have been familiar to many earlier generations of galley sailor, cannon and firearms had now become crucial elements in combat between galleys. Oared ships could never be as successful a platform for cannon as the much larger sailing ships. War galleys remained in use until the end of the 18th century, but their role in naval warfare became increasingly specialized and localized. The age of the sailing ship had arrived.

208
Battle of Red Cliffs: decisive battle fought on the river Yangtze during the declining years of the Han Dynasty

440–476
As Roman control collapses, Vandals use large fleet to dominate western Mediterranean

674–678
Arab siege of Constantinople. Byzantines employ Greek fire to defeat invasion fleet

1095
Launch of First Crusade: Italian maritime republics—Venice, Genoa, and Pisa—grow rich by shipping men and supplies to Holy Land

1204
Fourth Crusade: Constantinople sacked by Crusader forces

1340
Battle of Sluys: major battle between England and France at start of Hundred Years War

1453
Constantinople falls to the Ottomans

1492
Columbus crosses the Atlantic in search of India. Spain embarks on creation of empire in the New World

300 CE | 600 CE | 900 CE | 1200 CE | 1500 CE



Roman anchor
The use of metal for anchors began some time around 600 BCE. By Roman times most were made of a combination of wood and iron.

655
Battle of the Masts: Arabs win first naval victory over the Byzantines

793
First recorded Viking raid—on Lindisfarne in northern England

1185
Battle of Dan-no-Ura: decisive victory of Minamoto clan over their rivals the Taira for control of Japan

1282–87
War of the Sicilian Vespers: Aragon emerges as major sea power under Italian admiral Roger di Lauria

1379–80
War of Chioggia: Venice defeats its principal rival Genoa

1571
Battle of Lepanto: coalition of Christian powers led by Spain and Venice inflicts first major defeat on Ottomans at sea